

Session 9: Hard Heart

Key Takeaways

- Pharaoh's heart is described in two ways: heavy, implying that he was guilty of injustice, and hard, meaning “resolute.”
- God knew Pharaoh would resist, but he gave him many chances. Pharaoh’s evil reaches a point of no return, so God bends Pharaoh’s evil to his purposes and lures him into his own destruction.

Pharaoh’s Heart: Two Views

Heavy Heart = Guilty

YHWH co-opts an Egyptian concept expressed in the Book of the Dead where the gods weigh a dead person’s heart on a balance against a feather. A heart heavier than the feather is guilty of injustice. YHWH finds Pharaoh guilty by his own standards.



Papyrus of Hunefer (1275 B.C.E.). [Wikimedia](#).

“Judgment scene from the Book of the Dead. In the three scenes from the Book of the Dead (version from 1275 B.C.E.) the dead man (Hunefer) is taken into the judgment hall by the jackal-headed Anubis. The next scene is the weighing of his heart, with Ammut awaiting the result and Thoth recording. Next, the triumphant Hunefer, having passed the test, is presented by the falcon-headed Horus to Osiris, seated in his shrine with Isis and Nephthys” (British Museum).

Hard Heart = Resolute

As in Hebrew, the Egyptian concept of a hard heart is not "cruel" but "resolute". YHWH inverts the positive Egyptian concept of stoutheartedness and shows that Pharaoh’s ideals are contrary to YHWH’s. Pharaoh fails to define good and evil on YHWH’s terms.

Who Is Doing What Kind of Hardening?

	קשה (<i>qšh</i>) ≈ hard	חזק (<i>ḥzq</i>) ≈ strong	כבד (<i>kbd</i>) ≈ heavy
Commission		4:21 Yahweh > Pharaoh (future)	
Second Commission	7:3 Yahweh > Pharaoh (future)		
Staff > Snake		7:13 Pharaoh (<i>qal</i>)	
Nile > Blood		7:22 Pharaoh (<i>qal</i>); “he would not listen”	7:14 Pharaoh (state; adj); “he refuses”
Frogs			8:15[11] Pharaoh > Pharaoh
Gnats		8:19[15] Pharaoh (<i>qal</i>); “he would not listen”	
Flies			8:32[28] Pharaoh > Pharaoh
Cattle (Plague)			9:7 Pharaoh (state; <i>qal</i>); “he did not send away the people”
Boils		9:12 Yahweh > Pharaoh	
Hail		9:35 Pharaoh (<i>qal</i>)	9:34 Pharaoh & Servants > Pharaoh & Servants
Theological Function of Exodus 4:24-25. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).			

	קשה (<i>qšh</i>) ≈ hard	חזק (<i>ḥzq</i>) ≈ strong	כבד (<i>kbd</i>) ≈ heavy
Locusts		10:20 Yahweh > Pharaoh	10:1 Yahweh > Pharaoh & Servants
Darkness		10:27 Y > Pharaoh	
Death of Firstborn		11:10 Yahweh > Pharaoh	
Firstborn Consecrated	13:15 when Pharaoh > Pharaoh (summary)		
Sea of Reeds		14:4 Yahweh > Pharaoh (future)	
Sea of Reeds		14:8 Yahweh > Pharaoh	
Sea of Reeds		14:17 Yahweh > Egyptians (future)	
Theological Function of Exodus 4:24-25. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).			

- Generally speaking, causation shifts from Pharaoh to YHWH. (Exception: Hail falls in the second group of five, but Pharaoh and his servants make their hearts heavy.)
- Pharaoh never makes his own heart “strong” (resolute), he always makes it “heavy” (guilty).
- YHWH only makes Pharaoh’s heart “heavy” (guilty) once. YHWH almost always makes it “strong” (resolute).
- YHWH and Pharaoh each make his heart “hard” once.

Pharaoh’s Heart in the Literary Design of Exodus

Plague 1 חזק כבד שלח	Plague 4 כבד שלח	Plague 7 חזק כבד שלח
Pharaoh's Heart in the Literary Design of Exodus. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).		

In the morning Forewarning Magicians Staff Did not listen	In the morning Forewarning Did not send	In the morning Forewarning Stretch hand Staff Did not send Never before
Plague 2 כבד שלח Forewarning Magicians Staff Did not listen	Plague 5 כבד שלח Forewarning Did not send	Plague 8 חזק כבד שלח Forewarning Stretch hand Did not send Never before
Plague 3 חזק Magicians Staff Did not listen	Plague 6 חזק Did not listen	Plagues 9/10 חזק חזק הלך שלח Forewarning (#10) Stretch hand Did not send Never before
Pharaoh's Heart in the Literary Design of Exodus. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).		

- Pharaoh imposes “heavy” labor and ends up “heavy-hearted.”
- Moses “strengthens” the snake, while YHWH “strengthens” Pharaoh (Exod. 4:4, 21).
- YHWH sends “heavy” swarms of flies, plague on livestock, hail, and locusts in response to Pharaoh’s “heavy heart” in those episodes (*lex talionis*).
- Even in passages where causation of the heavy/strong heart is not explicit, the context makes clear that Pharaoh is at fault (Exod. 7:14; 9:7; 7:22; 8:19[15]).
- The heavy heart goes with inaction, while the strong heart goes with refusal to listen.
- YHWH’s “strong arm” overcomes Pharaoh’s “strong heart” (Exod. 6:1; 13:3, 9, 14, 16; 14:31).
- YHWH’s “glory” (heaviness) outweighs Pharaoh’s “heavy heart” (Exod. 14:4, 17-18).

Does Pharaoh Lose Free Will?

“Exodus gives no sign that Pharaoh longed to submit to Yahweh as his sovereign and was prevented from doing so; he received numerous rebukes, explanations, and commands that imply opportunity to submit.”

Coover-Cox, Dorian (2006). “The Hardening of Pharaoh’s Heart in Its Literary and Cultural Contexts.”
Bibliotheca Sacra. 163.

Reflection Question

Do you find any of the explanations from this session helpful in wrestling with God hardening Pharaoh’s heart?